Braving Storms

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Braving Storms

by LuNimouse

Summary

Thunderstorms make Mydei anxious. Nothing good ever happens while it's storming.

During a particularly bad storm, Phainon unexpectedly stops by and ends up comforting him.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Nothing good ever happens when it's storming.

Mydei's earliest memories are of him swimming in the sea of souls, trying to stay above the waves but getting violently whipped around by them instead. Fighting his way to the surface, only to be met by even more water as the rain mercilessly clashes across his face. With every lightning crack he'd be overcome by a rush of panic when the monsters all around him briefly got illuminated, followed by the uncertainty of whether or not they spotted him too, whether or not one of them would be trying to hunt him down.

He didn't know what thunder was until years later when he was back on land. As a child, he'd always assumed it was the roaring of a particularly big monster getting agitated by the sudden flashes of lightning, so of course he was freaking out when he could hear the cries of that great sea monster even back in Kremnos, so far away from the ocean. For a long time, he would rush outside with his sword whenever he heard thunder clash, prepared to fight whatever horrifying creature was out there, and feeling confused when there was not a single monster in sight.

He never managed to get used to the sound, even after he learned what thunder truly was. It always put him on edge, called to that deep-seated survival instinct.

It was storming during many of his comrades' deaths, too.

When Leonnius died having his legs cut off, his screams were covered by the roaring of thunder in the distance.

When Perdikkas was shot, his blood got washed away by a river of rain, his lifeless face illuminated only by the occasional flash of lighting.

Hephaestion's last words, too, were accompanied by the foreboding sound of thunder before getting washed away by a heavy shower of rain, leaving Mydei all alone in the thunderstorm on the eve before the battle against his father.

It was storming when his closest companions died, and Mydei wouldn't be surprised if he was told that it was storming when his father threw him into the Sea of Souls, too.

So, naturally, Mydei isn't very fond of thunderstorms. They put him on edge until this day, and he wouldn't complain if he never had to sit through one of them ever again… But even in Okhema he isn't spared from the occasional thunderstorm.

This particular one has been going for at least a day now. When it first started, Mydei was in town running some errands for Tribbie. The first clash of thunder caught him so off guard, he almost knocked over a woman just passing by him. After that, he rushed to his room before anyone would be able to watch him panic.

The last thing he needs is for word to spread around that he's scared of thunderstorms — He'd be the talk of all of Okhema then: The Kremnoan Crown Prince and one of Aglaea's esteemed Chrysos Heirs, terrified of storms.

So, he’s spent the day hiding away in his room. He's managed to keep his fear in check so far, but now that it’s getting later and later, he finds himself restless, riddled with anxiety. Worn down by hours and hours of heavy rain, thunder clashing, and wind howling.

Mydei has since tried to close all his windows to block out the storm, even going as far as to cover his ears with a pillow, but even that isn't enough to cover up the sound of the storm outside. If anything, it only makes it worse because the muffling makes it even harder to discern what exactly is happening outside.

No matter how much he tries to be prepared for the next roar of thunder, he can't help but jolt up every single time.

He just wants to sleep until it's over, but he's so on edge, his body practically refuses to fall asleep.

Every time he gets close to drifting off, his mind is dragged into the past and suddenly he's back in the Sea of Souls, getting ripped around by the tides.

Mydei lets out a frustrated groan. He's never going to fall asleep like this. He tosses the pillow he used to cover his ears across the room, hitting a table and sending a bunch of manuscripts and a cup flying with a loud *clank*.

Mydei curses under his breath.

He sits up and rests his head in his hands. He hates feeling like this, filled with tension that he just can’t seem to get out, no matter how hard he tries.

He shouldn't be scared at all, but he just can't get used to this kind of weather.

Maybe he’ll feel better if he goes for a walk.

He dreads the idea of going outside right now with nowhere to take cover from the storm, but it really seems like the best solution if he wants to burn some of this energy.

Maybe once he’s outside and sees that there’s no horrifying sea monsters lurking anywhere he will feel calm enough to fall asleep. There shouldn’t be a lot of people around at this hour either, so hopefully nobody will see him like this.

He gets up from his bed, preparing himself to step outside. He takes one last, deep breath to brace himself, and…

Mydei's hand hovers over the door handle when another loud crack makes him jump, a wave of panic immediately rushing over him. He can’t go outside. Not like this.

His gaze falls to his sword leaning against the wall. He shouldn't have to carry a weapon around just to go for a walk. Logically speaking, he knows there are no monsters waiting for him outside, but Mydei has always felt more secure with the heavy, reliable weight of a weapon sitting in his hands.

He promptly grabs it, fingers wrapping tightly around the cold steel until his knuckles turn white.

Mydei finally opens the door – And almost screams when he's met by someone standing right outside his room.

Instinctively he swings his weapon, only to smash it into the doorframe when the other person just barely manages to dodge his attack.

“Woah there, careful,” the person shouts, letting out a small laugh. “Give me a warning before you swing at me, will ya?”

Their laugh cuts through the clouds of anxiety, pulling Mydei back into reality. He sets his weapon down with a deep breath.

He could recognize that laugh anywhere, and it has never once meant danger for him.

He blinks and looks over at where the person jumped when dodging his strike, only to be met with a familiar tuft of white hair and bright blue eyes staring back at him.

“You’ve made quite the dent there,” Phainon notes, leaning in to examine the doorframe. He runs his fingers over the cracked wood. A grin forms on his lips. “Now I kind of understand why Aglaea doesn't want us sparring inside.”

Mydei follows his gaze, cringing a little when he sees the obvious dent. He'll have to explain that to Aglaea come the next action hour. A thought that is *almost* more terrifying than sitting through a thunderstorm.

But right now, his attention is caught by the man standing right in front of him, still admiring the door frame in wonder.

Mydei’s embarrassment at his *almost* smashing the door to bits quickly transforms into irritation.

“What in Nikador’s name are you doing, Deliverer?”

Phainon blinks at him, staring back at Mydei with wide eyes. “Hey, I'm not the one swinging weapons at unsuspecting people…” He defensively lifts his hands in the air, laughing. “Why are you carrying your weapon around in here anyway? Do you sleep like that?”

Mydei crosses his arms. “Stop trying to switch the topic. What are you doing just standing around in front of my room at this hour?”

“Actually,” Phainon pipes up, “ I was just about to knock when you ripped open the door and tried to kill me.” He sighs wistfully. “I simply wanted to check on my dear friend, but was met with hostility instead, and now *I’m* the bad guy?”

Mydei scoffs. “Stop being dramatic, you dodged it.”

Phainon laughs heartily. “Luckily for you. Some of us aren't immortal, you know. So maybe, the words coming out of your mouth right now should be *"I'm sorry”* instead. To which I’d respond with “*I forgive you”*, by the way.” He pats Mydei’s shoulder and pushes past him, stepping inside like this is his room. With how often he just bursts in here, it might as well be. “But to answer your previous question, I couldn't sleep, so I went for a walk… Then I heard a loud noise in here and wanted to check on you, you know, *like a good friend."* He looks around, noticing the mess on the floor from when Mydei threw his pillow across the room. “Did you fall out of bed or something?”

Mydei sighs. Phainon’s ability to irritate him within mere minutes of showing up should be studied. “I did not. Everything is fine, I just-” Mydei is caught off guard by another crack of thunder. The storm seems to have moved a lot closer. They must be almost at the heart of it now.

He completely loses his train of thought, so startled that he knocks down his sword, which hits the ground with yet another loud *clank*.

Phainon watches him with wide eyes. “Why so jumpy?” He asks, lightly tilting his head.

“It's nothing,” Mydei huffs. He clears his throat, trying to relax. Avoiding this kind of situation is exactly why he’s been hiding away in his room all day. He needs to stay calm before Phainon figures out why Mydei is so scared, because by the Titans, Mydei knows this man will be insufferable the moment he sees even the slightest hint of weakness in him. He needs to get Phainon to leave as soon as possible.

Crack. There’s an especially loud noise after what sounds like a lightning hitting one of the trees nearby, and Mydei lets out a pitiful yelp as he jumps into defensive position.

Phainon blinks at him and lets out a surprised laugh. “Calm down, it was just a lightning strike.”

Just a lightning strike.

Mydei straightens his posture and forces his shoulders to relax. “Of course, I know that,” he grumbles. That doesn’t keep the hairs on his neck from standing up or his heart beating out of his chest, though.

Phainon looks him over, kind of sceptical. A small smirk starts to bloom on his face, and Mydei knows he’s done for. “Don't tell me the great Mydeimos is scared of a little bit of lightning and thunder.”

“Shut up,” Mydei hisses through gritted teeth. “Just go home, I don’t need you mocking me right now.” Phainon and him tend to tease each other a lot, and he's never been *truly* bothered by their small jabs at each other, but this particular fear is something Mydei would rather not share with anyone. It’s a weakness he’d never want to admit, and *definitely* doesn't want to be teased for.

Thunder is roaring a lot more frequently now while rain clashes against the windows and the wind rattles on them like it's going to rip them away any second. It's almost deafening.

Mydei feels his unease growing, slowly wrapping around his chest and forming into a lump in his throat.

He sits down on his bed while muttering quiet curses, fingers digging into the mattress. He just wants to curl up under a blanket and hope for this to pass quickly. If only he could get Phainon to leave him alone.

“You really are scared, huh?” Phainon asks, taking a step closer.

“So what?” Mydei barks back, glaring up at Phainon. He’s about to yell at him to leave, physically force him out if he has to, but the words die in his throat when he notices Phainon’s expression.

He was expecting him to loom over him with that stupid, shit-eating grin of his, ready to tease him relentlessly and only laugh harder the more irritated Mydei gets. Instead, Phainon frowns at him with furrowed brows, seeming almost… Worried.

“Calm down, I won't make fun of you,” he assures Mydei. “If you want, I can stay so you’re not alone right now. It'll be more bearable then. I promise I’ll be nice.”

Mydei's first instinct is to tell him to leave. He's always dealt with his fear alone, and the thought of someone witnessing him scared is absolutely dreadful. But Phainon has already seen him like this, so what harm would it do if he stayed?

Truth be told, Mydei doesn’t hate the idea of Phainon staying here. He may be terribly irritating and a bit of a prick sometimes, but Mydei has always been able to trust him to watch his back in dangerous moments… So why should it be any different now?

Mydei huffs. “You better be. One laugh at me and I’m kicking you out.”

Phainon places a hand on his chest and smiles. “No laughing, I swear.” He seems hesitant for a moment, glancing down at Mydei. A few moments later, he sits down on the bed next to Mydei, their knees almost touching. He folds his hands in his lap.

“I was just a little taken aback,” he admits after a few seconds of silence. “I’ve never seen you like this before. To be honest, I would’ve thought a guy like you just… Isn’t scared of anything. I always imagined you to be like *“There is no word for **fear** in the Kremnoan language”*, you know?” He tries to imitate Mydei’s voice and breaks out into a small laugh at his attempt, immediately catching himself and trying to put on a serious face. He barely manages to conceal his amusement.

Mydei lightly shakes his head and lets out a small chuckle.

“No one is completely free of fear. It can be a useful tool for knowing when to retreat in battle, even Kremnoans respect that.” He relaxes a little more and sighs. “Fear was one of the first things I learned in the Sea of Souls. Whenever a storm came up, things got especially dangerous out there. It’s been ingrained into my mind.”

He's not sure *why* he's admitting to this now. Something about Phainon's stupid smile makes him want to entrust him with even the things he wants nobody else to know.

"No wonder you're so on edge." Phainon frowns. "You must be going into survival mode the moment a storm comes up." He's not wrong. Mydei only realizes now that he's been feeling like he's fighting for his life ever since that storm first came up.

Phainon hesitates a little before gently placing a hand on Mydei's shoulder. "Hey… You know you're safe here, right? Those monsters from back then won't get to you here in Okhema."

Mydei huffs. "I'm aware. But it still makes me uneasy. I know it's irrational, but it scares me anyway."

Phainon doesn't seem to have a clever response for once, so they just quietly sit there, staring at the ground in front of them.

"You know," Phainon pipes up after a while, "I think I understand what you're going through. Sometimes I randomly remember what happened back in Aedes Elysiae, and suddenly I'm worried the Black Tide will come to Okhema and turn everyone I care about into titankin right in front of me."

"That's not going to happen," Mydei says. "Not as long as we're under Kephale's protection."

Phainon looks up at him and gives him a sad smile, tilting his head. "And you won't have to fight any sea monsters here. The ocean is miles away."

Mydei sighs. He has a point. These fears are hardly ever rational.

Phainon smiles. "But even when I get scared, I remember I'm safe here as long as the other Chrysos Heirs are there. I know we'd fight off any danger together." He gently bumps his shoulder against Mydei's. "That goes to you, too. Even if a strange sea creature suddenly appeared here, you wouldn't have to fight it off alone. Not when I'm here with you." He lets out a small laugh. "You know I'd be itching to help you defeat some weird monster. We could see who can kill it faster."

Mydei has always felt so alone when a storm came up, he never even considered the possibility that he didn't have to face them on his own. But Phainon is right. No matter what monsters came here, he wouldn't have to deal with them all alone.

He glances back at Phainon and cracks a small smile. "Obviously I would win. I'm far more experienced at slaying sea monsters than you."

Phainon grins back at him, about to retort something.

At that moment, there's another crack of thunder. Mydei tries not to jump this time, but the fear is still written all over his face. He quietly curses. Getting used to this will be a long, slow process, even now.

Phainon watches him, his head slightly tilted. He frowns as he sees Mydei's eyes widen once again.

“How about we lie down and you just try to sleep for the night?” He carefully offers, stretching out his arms a little. “I'll be there in case anything happens. You can relax.”

Mydei gives him a sceptical look. The idea of it sounds horribly embarrassing, having to cuddle up with someone because he can't fall asleep otherwise.

On the other hand, Phainon has proven quite sensible in all of this so far, being very understanding of Mydei's fear. So surely he wouldn't mock Mydei for accepting a hug, either, right?

The idea of it does sound comforting.

A little hesitant, Mydei settles down, and Phainon lies down next to him. He carefully wraps an arm around Mydei, pulling him closer ever so slightly.

Mydei feels tense at first. He's never really cuddled with anyone, let alone allowed someone to comfort him when he's scared. He isn't sure what to do with his hands, shifting around until he finally drapes his arms around Phainon, who patiently waits for him to settle down.

He rests his head against Phainon's chest.

It's a strange feeling having someone lie next to him, but it's not completely unwelcome. Phainon feels warm and kind of soft, and something about lying next to him just feels *right*.

Mydei hates the idea of letting down his guard, of letting somebody else look out while he's asleep.

But if there's somebody he can trust to have his back and watch over him, it's probably Phainon. No matter how often they have disagreements and bash each others' heads in, Phainon is reliable when it counts.

Slowly, Mydei closes his eyes. The steady rhythm of Phainon's heartbeat gives him something to focus on other than the storm outside. Mydei didn't even realize how exhausted he was until sleep washes over him.

He tries to hang out, to stay awake and remain alert, but then he briefly feels one of Phainon's hands brush over his hair and he knows he can allow himself to drop into sleep.

He'll be fine as long as Phainon is there with him.

He finally feels safe.

End Notes

These are my blorbos, I love them so so much!

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